AI Leaders & Operators Summit, Manchester, 3 November 2026

AI adoption is an operating system, not ~~a tool rollout.~~

1	2	3	4	5
Delegate	Own	Approve	Verify	Stop

Hammed Ajibade, Head of Engineering, Thankyu (Pulse)

Usage went up. Nothing else changed.

What we rolled out

- Licences
- A training session
- A usage dashboard

What we didn't decide

- What it may do
- Who owns it
- Who approves it
- How it is checked
- How it stops

90%

of the tech professionals DORA (DevOps Research and Assessment) surveyed use AI at work.

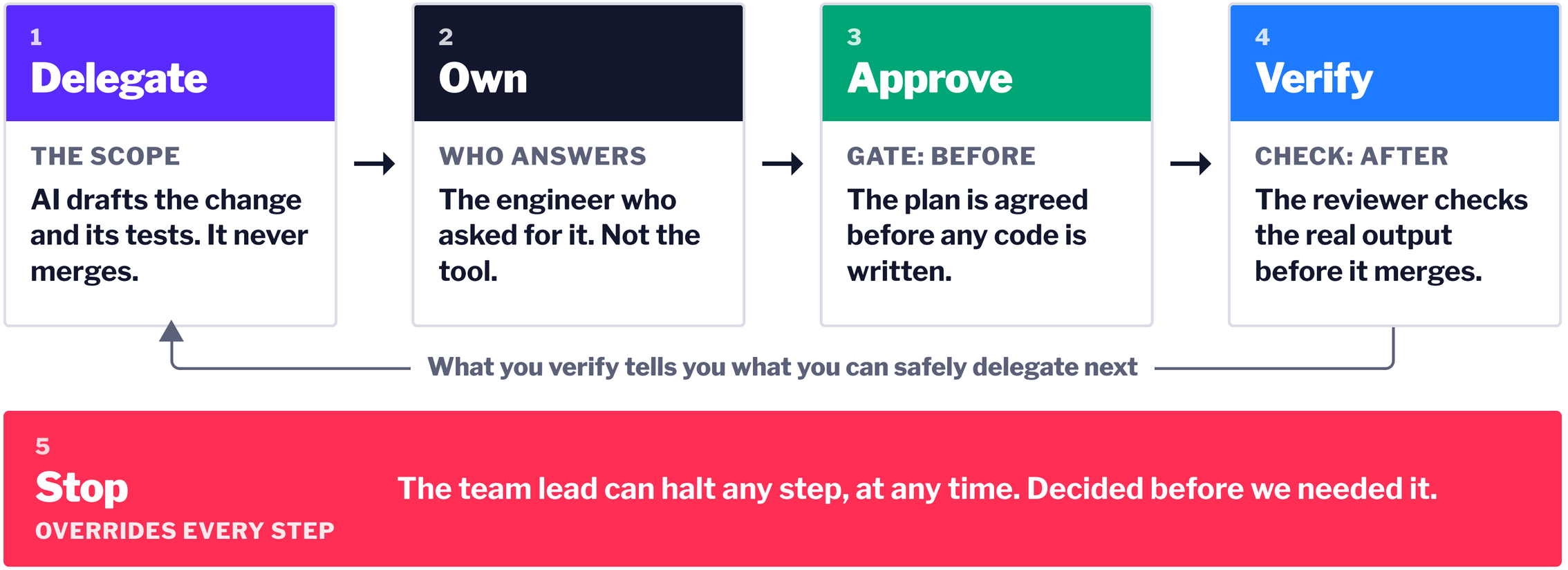
37%

of organisations McKinsey surveyed say AI has added anything to profit. Unchanged in a year.

DORA, State of AI-assisted Software Development, 2025.
McKinsey, The State of AI in 2026.

Five decisions. One system.

Run on one real workflow: an AI-drafted code change on my team



How much should AI do on its own?

Ask one question: if it goes wrong, who notices?

WHO NOTICES	FOR EXAMPLE	WHAT AI MAY DO	WHOSE NAME IS ON IT
Only the team	Tidying internal code, drafting notes	**AI does it on its own**	**Whoever asked for it**
A customer	A reply to a customer, a change they will see	**AI drafts, a person signs off**	**The team lead**
Money, personal data or the board	A refund, a payment, someone's records	**Only with a written approval**	**The senior leader responsible**

Every row has a name. "The AI did it" is never an answer. Idea from Will Larson, engineering leader and author

Don't trust the summary. Check the evidence.

- **Agree the plan before the work starts**
  Mistakes are cheapest to fix before anything is built.
- **Make sure the check can fail**
  A check that has never caught anything proves nothing.
- **Look at the result, not the AI's report**
  My agent said "all tests passed". They had failed.

76%

more code changes added with no human review at all. AI writes more than people can check.

Faros AI (engineering analytics), The Speed Trap, 2026. Data from 22,000 developers.

Stop

Know how to switch it off. Before you need to.

What you need

One named person who can switch it off.

An off switch the AI tool can't override.

Someone who owns the cost, with a limit.

Warning signs: pause it and fix it

Reviews get quicker	but problems aren't falling
More people use AI	but work isn't getting done faster
A change goes live	and nobody can say who approved it
People use their own AI	the approved route is too slow
The cost keeps rising	and nobody owns the bill

Don't roll out a tool.

Install an operating system.

On Monday, pick one AI workflow your team already uses. Fill in the five decisions for it.

The one you can't answer is next week's work.

Slides

Agent Mandates

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